beyond metropolitan cities. Primary stroke units and rural communities cannot be left behind if we are serious about improving outcomes at a population level."

Offering a global perspective, **Dr. Jeyaraj Pandian, President, World Stroke Organization,** highlighted the structural disparities that continue to affect stroke care delivery across India.

"A significant shortage of neurologists continues to drive regional disparities in stroke care across the country. Stroke care infrastructure remains uneven, with certain states advancing considerably faster than others," he noted.

He further pointed to the transformative potential of digital and mobile technologies. "Mobile stroke units offer a practical and proven solution for bridging gaps in access to timely care, while telemedicine and AI-enabled tools hold immense potential to extend stroke expertise to underserved populations."

A key institutional voice at the conclave was that of **Yatharth Super Specialty Hospitals, the title partner for the initiative. Speaking on the growing burden of stroke, Mr. Amit Singh, Group CEO, Yatharth Group of Hospitals, remarked:**

"India's stroke burden is growing — and increasingly, it is affecting younger populations. Stroke is no longer a condition confined to older age groups; it is emerging as a broader, society-wide healthcare challenge."

He further stressed that awareness and timely intervention remain critical gaps in India's stroke ecosystem. "Awareness, early symptom recognition, and timely access to care remain the three most critical gaps we must close. At the same time, scalable models such as hub-and-spoke systems can play a transformative role in improving stroke care access across geographies."

Emphasizing the importance of post-stroke care, he said, "Stroke treatment does not end at discharge. A comprehensive stroke care ecosystem must include post-stroke rehabilitation as an integral part of treatment, helping patients regain quality of life and functional independence."

The conclave also witnessed participation from several distinguished leaders and experts who brought deep clinical, academic, policy, and public health perspectives to the discussions. These included **Dr. Rajinder K. Dhamija,** Professor of Neurology and Director, Institute of Human Behaviour and Allied Sciences (IHBAS), and Chair, National Task Force on Brain Health, NITI Aayog; **Dr. P. Ganesh Kumar,** Scientist E & Head, Division of Noncommunicable Diseases, ICMR–National Institute of Epidemiology; **Dr. Tina Rawal,** Senior Research Scientist, Public Health Foundation of India (PHFI); **Prof. (Dr.) Kameshwar Prasad**, Emeritus Professor of Neurology, AIIMS, New Delhi, and Dean (Research), Fortis CSR Foundation; **Dr. K. Madan Gopal,** Senior Health Sector Expert and Former Senior Consultant, NITI Aayog; and **Dr. Vijaya Pamidimukkala,** Immediate Past President, Indian Stroke Association, and Director, Ankineedu Stroke Centre, Andhra Pradesh. Their insights further enriched conversations around stroke policy, public health systems, clinical excellence, prevention strategies, and long-term rehabilitation frameworks in India.

Throughout the day, discussions covered the entire continuum of stroke care—from prevention and policy integration to acute management, rehabilitation, and long-term recovery. Experts deliberated on integrating stroke care within national NCD frameworks, strengthening financing mechanisms under Ayushman Bharat, and addressing the persistent gap between policy intent and implementation.

The conclave also placed strong emphasis on prevention and early diagnosis, with discussions around hypertension control, diabetes management, FAST awareness, and the role of primary care systems in reducing stroke incidence. **In line with this, Voice of Healthcare has also launched a nationwide hypertension awareness campaign under the banner "BP Ko Halke Mai Na Le", aimed at raising awareness around the silent dangers of uncontrolled blood pressure and its role in triggering life-threatening conditions such as stroke, cardiac arrest, and kidney failure.**

Another major focus area was stroke accreditation and the importance of building standardized, stroke-ready hospitals capable of delivering consistent outcomes. Experts highlighted the need for quality protocols, trained multidisciplinary teams, and structured emergency response pathways to strengthen stroke care delivery across institutions. Clinical discussions also explored reducing treatment delays, improving access to thrombolysis and thrombectomy, and strengthening pre-hospital triage systems and emergency coordination. The growing role of AI, tele-stroke networks, and digital health platforms in improving access to care—particularly in underserved and remote regions—emerged as a recurring theme across sessions.

One of the key highlights of the conclave was the launch of the **Region's first ever Hospital led Stroke Patient Support Network, headed by Dr.(Prof.) Kunal Bahrani, Chairman & Group Director – Neurology at Yatharth Hospitals,** aimed at creating a structured continuum of care for stroke survivors—from emergency treatment and rehabilitation to long-term recovery and support.

Speaking on the initiative, Dr. Bahrani emphasized that stroke recovery must be viewed as a long-term continuum rather than a single episode of hospital-based treatment.

"A structured recovery pathway — supported by clinicians, caregivers, rehabilitation experts, and healthcare systems — is essential to improving long-term outcomes and quality of life for patients," he said.

He further highlighted that one of the biggest gaps in India's stroke ecosystem is the absence of organized post-stroke support for survivors and caregivers. "Many patients survive stroke, but continue to struggle physically, emotionally, socially, and financially once they leave the hospital. Through this initiative, our aim is to create a structured continuum of care — from emergency response and rehabilitation to home-based support and long-term recovery. Caregiver empowerment, rehabilitation access, and continuity of care must become central pillars of stroke management in India."

The conclave concluded with a strong consensus that improving stroke outcomes in India will require coordinated action across stakeholders—integrating policy, clinical expertise, technology, infrastructure, and patient-centric care systems. By bringing together leaders from across the healthcare ecosystem, the VOH National Stroke Conclave reinforced the urgent need to move beyond awareness and toward scalable, implementation-driven solutions for stroke care in India.

